# How Much Slave Paprika is in the U.S. Supply Chain?

*Origin Verification of Retail Paprika Products in a Major U.S. Metropolitan Market*

FloraTrace, Inc. • March 2026

**Key Findings**

**100%:** Percentage of retail paprika products originating from **China**.
**61%:** Percentage of paprika products originating from the **Xinjiang Uyghur Autonomous Region** (XUAR).
**71%:** Percentage of products that claimed or implied USA origin, but actually from the XUAR.

## Background

Paprika is widely used as a seasoning in many cuisines. The food industry incorporates paprika into various product formulations, including snacks, seasonings, sauces, and marinades. The global paprika market was valued at approximately $543 million in 2024. The U.S. is heavily import-dependent: the U.S. is a major importer of paprika, sourcing from countries like Spain, Hungary, and China. But this well-intentioned shift has a dark side: **the vast majority of the world's paprika comes from a region built on forced labor.**

### What Is "Slave Paprika"?

An estimated 70% of the world's paprika peppers are grown in the **Xinjiang Uyghur Autonomous Region** (XUAR or "Xinjiang") of China. It is well-known that the Chinese government operates state-controlled agricultural programs that rely on the systematic coercion and forced labor of Uyghur and other Turkic Muslim minorities. The U.S. government has determined that conditions in XUAR constitute genocide. In plain terms, paprika harvested under these conditions is ***slave paprika***. The **Uyghur Forced Labor Prevention Act** (UFLPA) creates an assumption that any goods from the XUAR are produced with forced labor and are therefore **illegal to import into the USA**.

Not all Chinese paprika is boycotted. Legitimate paprika production occurs in Gansu, Inner Mongolia, and Shanxi. XUAR dominates production with XUAR paprika being routinely transshipped, relabeled, and mixed with products from other origins to disguise its true provenance. **Traditional paper-based traceability is limited in this environment.** Claims offer no assurance whatsoever that XUAR materials are absent from the supply chain.

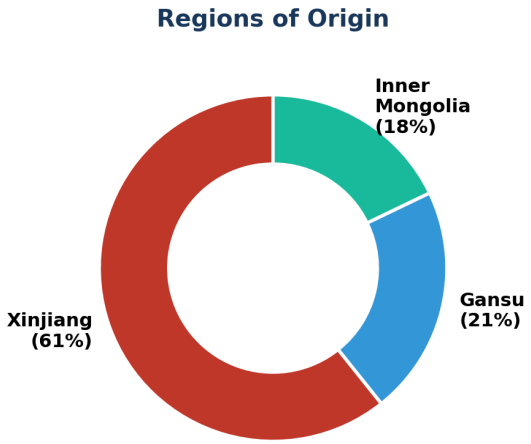
## Study Design

**Twenty-eight (28) paprika products** were purchased across **six (6) retailer categories** in a major U.S. metropolitan market: big box retailers, mainstream supermarkets, natural/organic grocers, food-service warehouses, specialty spice shops, and multi-cultural markets. Products were packaged in glass/plastic jars or plastic bags and ranged in price from **$0.45/oz to $10.64/oz**. Products included major national brands, store/private label brands, organic-certified products, and niche labels.

## Results

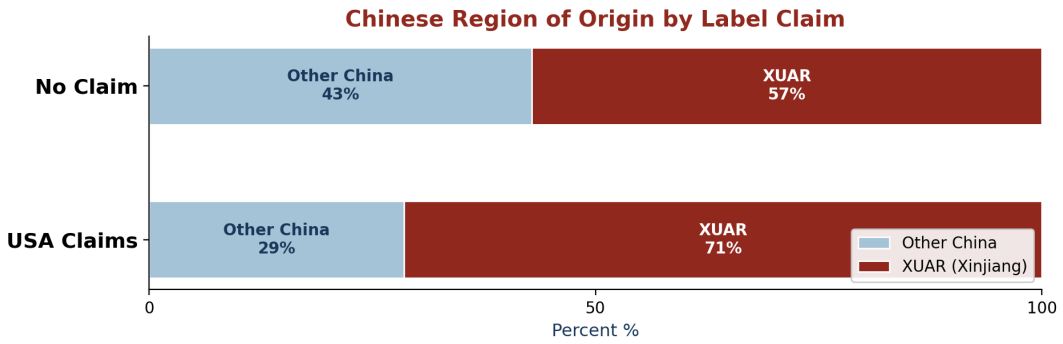
### Xinjiang Paprika Is Everywhere

All tested products were revealed to be from **China**, with the majority the **Xinjiang Uyghur Autonomous Region (61%).** The remaining products originated from Gansu or Inner Mongolia.



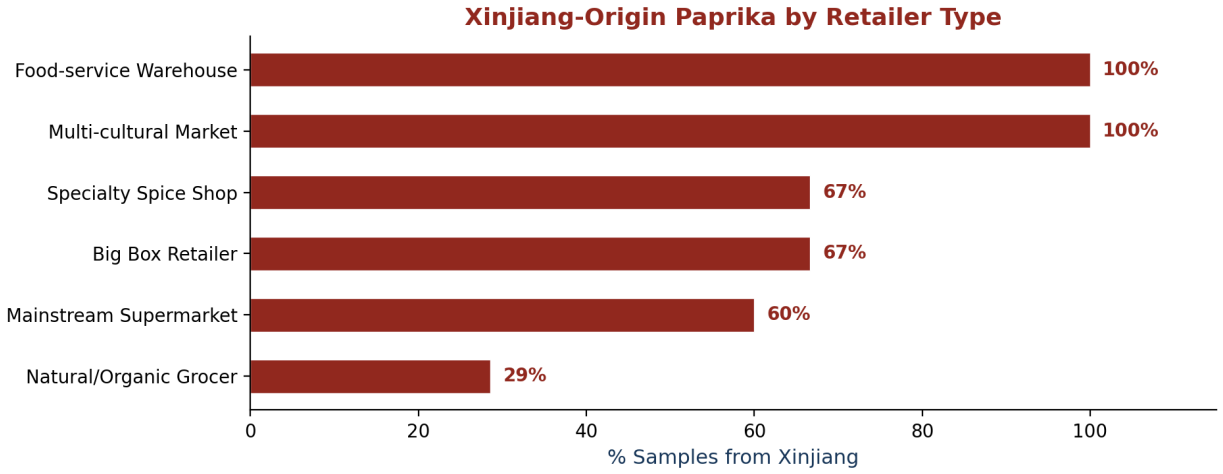

### Origin Claims are Meaningless

Only 25% of the products in this survey claimed any origin information, all of which suggested the product was from the USA. Claims include: "Packed in USA," "Product of USA," "Made in USA," and "Country of Origin: USA." In no cases was the actual paprika within the packaging from the USA, all were from China with a significant majority from Xinjiang (71%). Of the products with no origin claim, 57% were from Xinjiang.



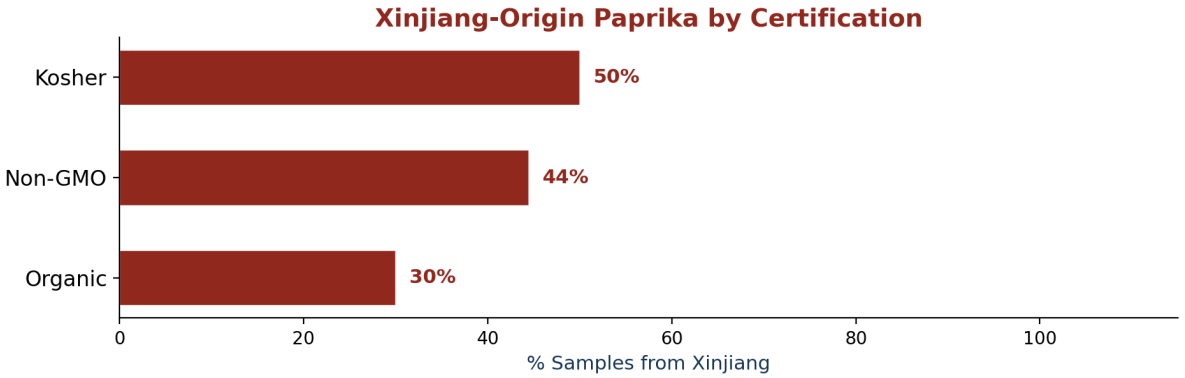

## Slave Labor in Your Pantry

Xinjiang-origin paprika was not limited to discount or perceived lower-quality products. It was found across **all six retailer categories**, from food-service warehouses to premium organic grocers and specialty spice shops. While no category was free of XUAR-origin materials, some retailer types are better than others. Natural/Organic Grocers were markedly better than all other categories, with comparatively lower occurrence (29%) of paprika products originating from Xinjiang. All other retailer categories had significant numbers of products on shelves that originated from XUAR.




## Third-Party Certifications Don't Eliminate XUAR Risk

Consumers view products certified by third-parties as of higher quality and the brands providing these products as above-board. This study found 30-50% of the certified "organic", "Non-GMO Project Verfied", and Kosher products were from Xinjiang. Products not labeled as organic or verified were more likely to be from Xinjiang, with 70-90% of products not carrying a third-party verification were from Xinjiang.



## Slave Labor at All Price-Points

Price was an overall weak indicator of geographic origin. Higher priced products were just as likely to come from XUAR as not. However, the median prices for products originating from Xinjiang was about $0.50/oz less than non-XUAR products. The median price for XUAR and non-XUAR products was $2.05/oz and $2.56/oz, respectively.

Products originating from Xinjiang had a significantly higher variation in price/oz compared to non-XUAR products. The middle 50% of prices for products from Xinjiang ($4.21 - $1.13 = $3.08/oz) had a wider spread than products from non-XUAR regions in China ($3.85 - $2.35 = $1.50/oz). In fact, both the highest ($10.64/oz) and lowest ($0.45/oz) priced products originated from Xinjiang.

# Implications

This survey reveals a pervasive, systemic failure in the U.S. paprika supply chain. Every product tested - across every price point, every retailer type, and every category from value to premium organic - was Chinese in origin. The majority came from a region under forced-labor embargo. American consumers are unknowingly buying paprika that:

- **Is uniformly Chinese in origin despite no products being labeled as such**: a complete disconnect between what the shelf says and what the product actually is;
- **Is illegal under U.S. law**: 61% of products originated from Xinjiang, a region embargoed under the UFLPA, yet there is currently **no CBP enforcement in place for paprika**;
- **Carries fraudulent origin claims**: every product claiming U.S. origin was Chinese, and 71% of those were from the forced-labor region;
- **Renders organic and premium certifications meaningless**: organic-certified products contain materials from XUAR state-controlled agricultural operations built on coerced labor.

The question facing every participant in this supply chain - from CBP to importers to brand owners to retailers - is straightforward: ***how much slave paprika is acceptable?*** The answer should be zero. But without scientific verification, there is no way to know - and without enforcement, there is no incentive to find out.

### What Needs to Happen

**Enforcement:** CBP must extend UFLPA enforcement to paprika and paprika oleoresin. Scientific origin verification tools exist today to support port-of-entry testing, as CBP has already done for cotton.

**Due Diligence:** Importers, brand owners, and retailers must move beyond paper-based compliance. Label claims and certificates of origin are demonstrably unreliable. Only scientific testing of the product itself can verify that forced-labor materials are absent.

**Labeling Reform:** Current regulations allow “Packed in USA” claims on products that are entirely foreign-grown. This creates a false impression of domestic origin and actively obscures forced-labor supply chain exposure.

***About FloraTrace:*** *FloraTrace, Inc. develops forensic origin-fingerprinting technology using isotope ratio and elemental analysis. Our models are specifically built to detect materials from the Xinjiang forced-labor region — the preponderant source of supply chain risk in the global paprika industry. Our reference databases are built from authenticated specimens covering all major paprika-growing regions in the world, with full chain-of-custody.*

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